

Hope is The Road to Home

by Sven Nilsen, 2026

In this essay, I provide a philosophical critique of Path Semantics that takes the approach of Hope as an idea and how it relates to thinking. I discuss the seemingly opposing forces Optimism and Criticism in Hope, supported by a working hypothesis about how Hope is processed in the human brain, to explain how Hope differs from Desire in general.

Little scientific research has been done so far on how Hope is processed in the human brain and few philosophers have explored in depth Hope as an idea. In the past year, Hope has gained interest as a topic among intellectuals. In part this interest around Hope is a result of the political situation in the world, that to many people seems dark when viewed through the negative world view of the news.

In reality, humanity continues making extreme amount of progress both on advancing human rights and in technology. The number of wars have gone down, murder rate has gone down and the temporary setbacks in human rights in some places also reveal structural flaws in institutions that have given people false hope. Thus, it is not necessarily regression in Hope overall in the world, but a clearer picture that makes the boundaries and limits on power more visible. That said, the climate crisis is getting significantly more serious and requires action that puts pressure on multiple fronts of governments. There are technological breakthroughs that enables government to act on the climate crisis, if they want to, but this requires new knowledge that takes time to learn and apply. Distractions of political instability makes this work difficult. In addition to traditional governmental structures, modern technology allows new forms of cooperation, often exponentially growing.

When people think about the world as a whole, it is easy to seek a definite conclusion of whether humanity will go extinct or not. There is a chance that humanity goes extinct within the lifetime of people that live today. If this happens, then theoretically, the age of the oldest person in the world at any moment will go down, until it reaches 0 years. Now, let us say that an extinction event happens in the next 80 years. Most likely, older people are less capable to survive, but with modern technology it is not self-evidence that the last humans alive will be young. Just more likely.

One can understand logically that if there is a total extinction of the human species, then there are certain events that have to take place before it happens, that are very unusual and strange to think about. A way to think about it is as somebody falling into a Black Hole. Past the event horizon, not even light can escape a Black Hole. So, the hard physical constraints of escape from a Black Hole requires staying outside of the event horizon. This does not mean in practice that somebody falling into a Black Hole can escape, even if they are outside the event horizon. It is possible, in theory, that somebody dies and orbits a Black Hole close to the event horizon without falling into it. A total extinction of the human species does not mean that there are hard physical constraints in place.

When contemplating a possible future event of total extinction of the human species, it is important to consider scenarios where humans get so distracted by all sorts of unusual and strange things happening around them, that they are not able to learn and apply knowledge in time about some technology that in principle could save them from extinction. This is the case for humanity today.

The technology needed to save humanity from total extinction already exists.

Thus, the actual problem here is not the technology itself, although easier to use technology could come around some time in the future, but learning and applying the knowledge of how to use this technology to save humanity from total extinction is so difficult, because of all the distractions.

The argument I made above, is logically correct. Since the technology to save humanity from total extinction already exists, the remaining question that determines total human extinction, is whether humanity is capable of learning and applying the knowledge in time to save themselves. That is all.

Most people, when they try to think about this situation, they try to figure out a yes/no answer to the question “Will humanity go totally extinct some moment in the next 80 years?”. There is a possibility that humanity will go totally extinct within some longer period of time, e.g. 160 years. However, technology might have advanced so far in that time and it could be so easy to use, that humans can learn and apply the knowledge in time to save themselves. This means, the most crucial time period is the next 80 years, where one might find a definitive answer yes/no, because beyond the next 80 years, there are plenty of reasons to believe this question is no longer easy to answer scientifically. If humanity goes total extinct within the next 80 years, then most likely this is not an event that is observable to most people, as most of them would die before the last ones die. In addition, there is a chance that the last people will be isolated from civilization, so that they are not actually aware of the human species as a whole going extinct in that sense, in the case their whole mental world is the territory where they live.

There are isolated tribes who get in touch with civilization today, who go through a rapid learning curve that there are things like roads and cars, becoming aware of the climate crisis and trying to warn the rest, not understanding why people would not simply learn and apply the knowledge needed in time to save themselves. It seems so obvious from the perspective of people that are used to think survival on daily basis, that taking a such action is reasonable. However, there are also tribes that see all the knowledge that civilization generated, that they put false hope in civilization. They believe civilization will take action, because they underestimate the difficulty of learning and applying the knowledge needed in time.

As strange as it sounds, the revelation of structural flaws of some institutions, where people have put false hope into, is actually increasing the chance that humanity can learn and apply the knowledge needed to use the technology in time to save themselves from total extinction. When people discover that they have been misplacing their hope, they can become depressed and feel more hopelessness, despite that the factual situation provides more Hope overall. There are new ways of cooperating that are possible due to modern technology, that are growing exponentially and can replace the functions of decaying institutions where people put their false hope into.

The reason there is so much political instability today in the world, is because there are competing ideologies about what the ways of cooperating mechanisms should be in the exponentially growing systems that will replace the functions of decaying traditional institutions. The two major competing factions are Democracy and Fascism. Democracy is growing much faster than Fascism overall, but is basically censored out from news, that are owned by billionaires that promote Fascism. This means, in reality, Democracy is winning, but it is not being reported. Due to most people observing that their traditional institutions are failing and revealing structural flaws, they feel more hopeless. These people have the highest chance to die first should humanity go totally extinct, while the central factions of Democracy and Fascism will keep competing with each other. They will be so distracted by fighting each other, that they are unable to use and apply the knowledge in time, of the technology that already exists. This is how total extinction of humanity will look like.

Since Democracy is growing much faster than Fascism, there is no hope that Fascism can win. So, it will be Democracy that puts itself in the best position to learn and apply the knowledge in time. If humanity goes totally extinct, then the most likely scenario is that Fascism pulls down Democracy in its grave. This could be some extreme scenario like nuclear war, but such extreme events are difficult to predict both when they might occur and what the consequences will be. Therefore, there are many possible scenarios where the situation changes significantly in the world.

One might think about the climate crisis from a very scientific point of view, where pollution from anthropic sources are the main cause. From the perspective of physics, this is true. However, one must distinguish physics as a domain of human knowledge from physics in the world. The perpetuation of the view that anthropic pollution is the main cause, also covers up the fact that from science in general, the evidence suggests that advocates of Fascism are laying the blame on consumers, because that is where Democracy is most active. History shows that people in general are overwhelmingly in support of action on the climate crisis, but this action is blocked by advocates of Fascism who see their path to victory as taking the chance they can to kill most people on this planet, while also growing exponentially, fast enough to take over the exponential growth of Democracy. It is all about modern technology and who grows faster.

Fascism today functions by privatization of the means of production to serve a big consumer market, so that consumers are abused psychologically to support fascist political candidates.

The more hopeless people feel, the more likely they are to consume a lot. In addition to spending more money, people also consume foods that are less healthy for their bodies. Higher sugar intake results in brain infections that trigger egoistic behavior, making people more likely to vote for fascist candidates. The fascist political candidates implement policies and laws designed to destruct Democracy, which in turn drive up hopelessness. This is the cycle that causes the climate crisis.

While pollution is the physical component of the climate crisis, from a broader scientific view point, the main cause of the climate crisis is overall psychological abuse.

In recent years, the term “woke” has been used to describe somebody that has become aware of the important role of overall psychological abuse, as the main cause for many important problems. This term is used by Democracy to advocate awareness about social injustice. The perpetuation of the view that the climate crisis has a physical cause of anthropic pollution, is used to by Fascism to verbally attack Democracy as people who are disconnected from reality. However, in reality, it is Fascism that is disconnected, since it can not win and tries to kill every person on the planet.

Fascism today openly advocates the destruction of civilization. It does so using the logical fallacy of appealing to authority, where a claim is advocated as true not based on the truth of the claim, but by the authority making that claim. One side of the problem in this argument, is that the claim itself is not true. Destruction of civilization is not motivated by the plan to rebuild it, but simply because the advocates of this argument do not want to go to jail from crimes they already committed. They know they are guilty of the crimes, so they need to resist arrest. That is why they advocate this delusional view, that civilization ought to be destructed. Another side of the problem in this argument, is that the authority is not real. The authority they use is based on religion, of a kind that would seem strange if true, consider a comparative perspective of normal religious worldviews.

Fascism justifies its actions using fallacious arguments that are not rational, because they are losing.

The overall strategy of Hope for humanity, is for Democracy to defeat Fascism before time runs out to learn and apply knowledge of technology that can save humanity from total extinction. There is no point in debating with Fascism, because their motivation is not about humanity itself, but because the advocates of Fascism do not want to go to jail. Their only chance to escape or delay justice, is to try make Fascism grow faster than Democracy through use of new technology. Since their motivation is not based on either physical nor psychological causes of the climate crisis, or even about the climate crisis itself, there is no benefit in pursuing a debate.

Democracy is the only faction that determines the outcome of the question whether humanity will go totally extinct the next 80 years. This puts great responsibility and pressure on leaders today.

When there are great stakes in place, yet also much Hope, it is easy that people are too critical toward leaders. Optimism is accompanied by Criticism. This Criticism is not fear based, because nobody fears that Democratic leaders will attempt to kill every person on the planet, like Fascism.

The philosophical views on Hope up to the moment of this essay, has focused on using Optimism as a bias that underlies Hope. In brain research, this bias is called “optimism bias”. However, optimism bias is not merely positive emotions about the future. Optimism bias is driven by people believing they have better access to information than others. A pessimistic person can also have optimism bias, because a pessimistic person places their Pessimism in the disbelief that other people can achieve good things. Thus, it is the same underlying mechanism, of believing one has better access to information, regardless of whether one is talking about Optimism or Pessimism.

Ole Petter Ottersen is a neuroscientist who served as the President of the University of Oslo from 2009 to 2017 and as the President of Karolinska Institutet in Sweden from 2017 to 2023. Ottersen was the Director of one of Norway’s Centres of Excellence (Centre for Molecular Biology and Neuroscience) from 2002 to 2009 and the coordinator of a Nordic Centre of Excellence in Molecular Medicine, funded by NordForsk, from 2005 to 2009. Ottersen has led one of UiO’s interdisciplinary initiatives (EMBIO; now UiO: Life Science) and one of the major national programs (Functional Genomics in Norway) of the Norwegian Research Council. From 2006 to 2009, Ottersen was Chief Editor of Neuroscience – the official journal of the International Brain Research Organisation (IBRO). He served as the Founding Chair (2016-2017) and Acting General Secretary (2023-2024) of the Guild of European Research-Intensive Universities – a European university network headquartered in Brussels that aims to contribute to the EU’s research, health, and innovation agendas. Ottersen has coordinated two neuroscience projects under the EU Framework Programme and is currently a member of the Governing Board of EBRAINS.

At May 24th 2026, Ottersen held a lecture at the philosophy festival “På Kanten” in Kragerø, a small city in Norway. This is the first lecture anyone has on record of being about Hope from the perspective of brain research. I was in the audience and got the chance to ask a question.

Ottersen’s conclusion in his lecture was that there is higher brain activity when people think about Hope in fMRI scans, compared to when they think about something disappointing. This higher activity when people think about Hope takes place in a different region of the brain than when people think about something that makes them scared. This was a pivotal moment in my thinking about Hope from a philosophical perspective, because I was immersed in the theme Hope of the philosophy festival.

I asked Ottersen whether there has been any research on how much of this activity is connected to Criticism. My argument was that Greed and Fear are closely related, for example in the case of over-fishing, the greed is motivated by the fear that everybody else will get it all and yourself get nothing. However, this Greed might also be accompanied with too little Criticism. I wondered whether this might have something to do with the less activity in the brain when people think about something that makes them scared. Another point I made, was that in the case of women’s rights, there is seemingly infinite amount of Criticism. I got this idea earlier in the philosophy festival that there is so much Criticism associated with Hope, not just Optimism. Was there any brain research on Criticism in this increased brain activity?

Ottersen answered that this is the reason why he held this lecture at the philosophy festival.

My hypothesis at this point was that Hope is not merely Optimism, but has elements of both Optimism and Criticism. Therefore, it is possible that a person might feel no Hope in the sense of Optimism, but at the same time feel Hope in the sense of Criticism.

When traveling home from this philosophy festival, I got an idea:

What if Hope was like the road home?

I was biking from Kragerø to the city where I live, so I had to spend more energy uphill than downhill. The idea was that Optimism might not be just in relation to the overall goal. Optimism is something people feel when things are going better, even though it is only temporary. When biking uphill, this can feel like Criticism, in the sense that you have to spend more energy and feel you get less results in return. Of course, when biking uphill, it is more important which path you take, so you spend less energy overall. When biking downhill, it is less important which path you take.

It seems to me most people think about humanity in the bigger picture, trying to determine the answer to whether humanity will go totally extinct or not. Some people think that the end of the road is just going over the edge of a cliff.

One can imagine a thought experiment, where there is a fork in the road and you have to go either left or right. To the left, there is a longer road, with more uphill than downhill. To the right, there is a shorter road, with more downhill than uphill. Based on this information alone, what choice do you make? If you do not know what is at the end of the road, then do you want to find that out quickly, or slowly? Does it matter to you that there is long road? Do you enjoy the journey? Or, does it matter that it is downhill and you get to know faster how the road ends?

I argue that based on this thought experiment, one can see how Optimism versus Criticism is not as simple as one might get through the first impression. Most people might have not thought very much about this at all, so it is a new idea to think about. Now, we consider Optimism as Seshatic biased and Criticism as Platonic biased. Based on this choice, we can use Joker Calculus to construct higher dualities of language biases about Hope.

For example, Critical Optimism is Optimism but from a perspective of Criticism.

Try imagine that you are biking uphill, but you know you will be biking downhill after you reached the top. This can be thought of as Critical Optimism. Your mind is oriented toward a better future than the present, but this does not imply that this better future will last for long. You feel Hope. Yet, it is Hope through a present moment of struggle. Does not mean that you are picturing some kind of utopia in the future, or something like that.

Another example is Optimistic Criticism. Criticism, but viewed from the perspective of Optimism.

Try imagine that you are biking downhill, but you see in front of you, that you will be biking uphill soon. This feeling of Optimistic Criticism can be very different, depending on the road ahead. Just because it is possible to give a language bias, does not mean that how you think is very precise. Still, it is more precise than if you only think about Hope in the sense of vague Optimism.

One person might have a different take on Optimistic Criticism than some other person. Perhaps you feel that the momentum you got so far will make the next part easier. An optimist might think that either they are currently biking downhill, or they will be soon. Being an optimist does not have to mean thinking unrealistically, just focusing on the easier parts of the road ahead of them. Likewise, a pessimist can focus on the harder parts of the road ahead of them. This way, you can see how both optimists and pessimists can have Hope, despite they do not think of Hope in the same sense. Furthermore, the language bias people use, does not tell us what they see at the end of the road. Both optimists and pessimists can use Critical Optimism and Optimistic Criticism, but differ by how they relate to these language biases in the present moment. This relation can change.

There is nothing about this notion of Hope that requires you to self-identify as either an optimist or a pessimist. You do not have to make it your identity. Just something in the present that depends on what your mind is paying attention to.

It is fully possible to be a person who believes that humanity will go totally extinct within 80 years, while also be somebody who is focusing their attention on the positive aspects of their own life.

Furthermore, there is no requirement to hope for something in the afterlife, regardless of how you think the road will end. What lies beyond the end of the road, might be irrelevant, but it also might be relevant to how you feel while on this journey. It depends.

From a pure language bias perspective, one can use Joker Calculus to describe how a person thinks about the road ahead of them, as the way they think about Hope. Now, there is a reason that in general, people associate Hope with Optimism. This is because in this analogy where Hope is The Road Home, one might be looking forward to something familiar, comforting and exciting at the end of the road. I use the term “home” because, it does not have to mean something that is exclusively positive. Maybe you forgot many of the problems you had at home before you went on your journey, so you are being optimistic on your way home that things will turn okay.

The point with The Road Home analogy, is to show that Hope can be complex. It does not have to be a single object of desire that will satisfy you.

For example, Hope in relationships with other people, might not be simply demands that other people will treat you better than before. It can also be a goal of becoming a better person yourself.

Some people think about planet Earth, as a home they want to have, but which they do not really feel they have yet. It can be like, pollution from anthropic emissions need to stop, before they feel that they can think they deserve to call this planet their home. When these people say that our planet is our home, then they might think humans ought to treat the planet as their home and not destroy it.

Another way to think about planet Earth, as being your home, right now. Still, there could be some distance from that goal and where you are, such as the difference between being in nature and being inside. So, you might Hope to spend more time in nature and this will in turn make you consume less and feel happier overall, regardless of what will happen to this planet as a whole in the future.

Whether the way you are thinking about planet Earth as some kind of long term future home, or in short term, the language biases that you use in your thinking can also be flexible. These different ways to think about a home are also not exclusive. You can be optimistic in one sense and pessimistic in another sense. There is room for having both positive and negative emotions.

Criticism is not the same thing as Fear. When people give you negative feedback, is not the same as physical violence. If you do something to help humanity, then some people might criticize you out of stupidity and for the wrong reasons. However, there can also be ways to improve what you are doing, that requires some feedback from others. There can also be a thing like too much criticism, that blocks people from acting, even though this criticism is not based on fear.

I believe the most crucial action humanity can take today, is to learn and apply knowledge of how to use technology to save itself from total extinction. In that role, it is important to be supportive of leaders who are doing the best they can and to be open minded about different approaches to mitigating the climate crisis. Tone down criticism and rather spend that critical thinking skill on fighting Fascism instead. Because, the biggest danger is distracting people from taking action, not the actions they are taking. In a car on the road home, the passengers should not distract the driver.